

SOARING SEABIRD

PELAGORNIS

With the largest wingspan of any bird ever, *Pelagornis* soared over the ancient seas in search of its next meal. Its fossils show that it had small toothlike structures in its beak, which would have helped it feed on fish and other small aquatic creatures. This prehistoric bird evolved around 40 million years after the extinction of the flying reptiles known as pterosaurs. Because *Pelagornis* had small legs relative to the size of its body, it was unable to take off when floating on the top of the water. Paleontologists think that it probably caught its prey by swooping close to the surface or by stealing the catch of smaller seagoing birds.

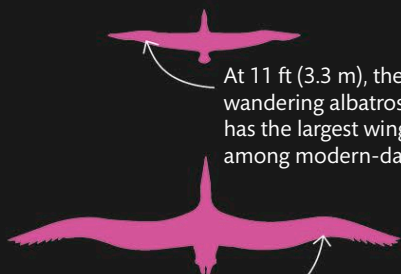
AT A GLANCE

- **WINGSPAN** 20–23 ft (6–7 m)
- **DIET** Fish and small marine creatures
- **LIVED** 28–25 MYA
- **HABITAT** Coastlines



STATS AND FACTS

The toothlike structures in *Pelagornis*'s beak are called "pseudoteeth" (fake teeth), as they do not have the tough enamel covering found in the teeth of most animals. These are not present in the fossils of younger specimens, which suggests that babies may have been toothless and reliant on their parents for food.



At 11 ft (3.3 m), the wandering albatross has the largest wingspan among modern-day birds.

The largest *Pelagornis* species had a wingspan of 23 ft (7 m).

